

Psalms 136

For His Mercy Endureth Forever

O give thanks unto the Lord; for he is good: for his mercy endureth for ever

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O give thanks unto the LORD; for he is good: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 2 O give thanks unto the God of gods: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 3 O give thanks to the Lord of lords: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 4 To him who alone doeth great wonders: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 5 To him that by wisdom made the heavens: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 6 To him that stretched out the earth above the waters: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 7 To him that made great lights: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 8 The sun to rule by day: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 9 The moon and stars to rule by night: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 10 To him that smote Egypt in their firstborn: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 11 And brought out Israel from among them: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 12 With a strong hand, and with a stretched out arm: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 13 To him which divided the Red sea into parts: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 14 And made Israel to pass through the midst of it: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 15 But overthrew Pharaoh and his host in the Red sea: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 16 To him which led his people through the wilderness: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 17 To him which smote great kings: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 18 And slew famous kings: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 19 Sihon king of the Amorites: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 20 And Og the king of Bashan: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 21 And gave their land for an heritage: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 22 Even an heritage unto Israel his servant: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 23 Who remembered us in our low estate: for his mercy endureth for ever:
- 24 And hath redeemed us from our enemies: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 25 Who giveth food to all flesh: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 26 O give thanks unto the God of heaven: for his mercy endureth for ever.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 136 is built on a single unbroken refrain—"for his mercy endureth for ever"—repeated after every line, turning the whole psalm into an antiphonal recitation likely sung responsively between worship leader and congregation. It surveys creation, the exodus, and the conquest, treating each act as another proof of the same unchanging mercy. Henry notes that the deliberate repetition is not poetic filler but theology by insistence: whatever else changes across history, this one fact does not.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The call to give thanks opens with escalating titles for God—good, God of gods, Lord of lords—each affirmation immediately answered by the refrain, establishing the psalm's rhythm before any specific act of God is even named.

Verse 4-9

Creation itself becomes the first evidence: God alone does great wonders, made the heavens by wisdom, stretched out the earth above the waters, made the great lights—sun to rule the day, moon and stars to rule the night. Cosmic order is presented as an act of mercy, not merely power.

Verse 10-15

The exodus is recounted in sequence: Egypt's firstborn struck, Israel brought out from among them with a strong hand and outstretched arm, the Red Sea divided, Israel led through its midst, and Pharaoh with his army overthrown in the very sea that had opened for God's people.

Verse 16-20

The wilderness journey and conquest follow: God leads His people through the wilderness, strikes down great kings, slays famous kings—Sihon of the Amorites and Og of Bashan again named specifically, as in Psalm 135—each victory answered by the same unchanging refrain.

Verse 21-22

The conquered land is given as a heritage, specifically as an inheritance to Israel, God's servant—the practical outcome of the preceding victories, land now safely possessed rather than merely promised.

Verse 23-26

The scope widens beyond ancient history to ongoing providence: God remembered His people in their low estate, redeemed them from their enemies, and gives food to all flesh, every living creature depending on Him for daily bread. The psalm closes by returning to its opening command: give thanks to the God of heaven, for His mercy endures forever.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

The relentless repetition of 'his mercy endureth for ever' insists that mercy, not mere power or convenience, is the true thread running through creation, the exodus, the conquest, and ongoing daily provision. No single act of God stands alone as an exception; each is folded into the same unbroken, dependable character.

Application for life today.

Try composing your own list of God's specific acts—past and present—each deliberately followed by 'his mercy endures forever,' letting the discipline of repetition shape how you actually feel the claim, not just believe it intellectually. Notice how the psalm treats daily food (v. 25) with the same weight as the exodus—consider training yourself to see ordinary provision as evidence of the same enduring mercy as dramatic deliverance. When current circumstances feel like they contradict God's mercy, use this psalm's refrain as a deliberate counter-declaration.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. If you wrote your own version of this psalm, which specific acts of God's mercy in your life would you list, each followed by the refrain 'his mercy endures forever'?

2. How does the psalm's inclusion of daily food (v. 25) alongside dramatic deliverance change how you notice God's mercy in ordinary provision?

3. What current circumstance makes God's enduring mercy hard to believe, and how might repeating this psalm's refrain deliberately counter that doubt?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).